

Notes on Regular Epimorphisms and the Monadicity of the Pullback Functor in an Exact Category

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These notes are based on the work of Sobral and Tholen [ST92], with some ideas drawn from Janelidze and Tholen [JT91]. Our goal is to prove the following theorem.

Theorem. In an exact category, if $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a regular epi, then p^* is a monadic functor.

We recall that a right adjoint is monadic if the comparison functor $K : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$ is an equivalence of categories, where T is the monad associated to the adjunction.

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
 (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) & \xrightarrow{K} & (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T \\
 \uparrow p_! & \nearrow F^T & \\
 \downarrow p^* & \nwarrow U^T & \\
 (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E) & &
 \end{array}$$

Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a category with pullbacks and let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{A}$. Consider the monad $T = p^*p_!$ associated to p . Let (C, γ) be an object in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)$ and let $(C, \gamma; \xi)$ be an object in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$ with $\xi : T(C) \rightarrow C$ an algebra.

Consider the pullback in $\mathcal{A}$.

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
 E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,C}} & C \\
 \text{proj}_{1,C} \downarrow & \nearrow \gamma & \downarrow p\gamma \\
 E & \xrightarrow{p} & B
 \end{array}$$

Thus, we have the span in $\mathcal{A}$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} & E \times_B C & \\ \text{proj}_{2,C} \swarrow & & \searrow \xi \\ C & & C \end{array}$$

Since ξ is also a morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)$, we have that $\gamma\xi = \text{proj}_{1,C}$

$$\begin{array}{ccc} E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\xi} & C \\ & \searrow \text{proj}_{1,C} & \swarrow \gamma \\ & E & \end{array}$$

Proposition 1. *Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a finitely complete category and let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{A}$. For any object $(C, \gamma; \xi)$ in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$, with T the monad associated to p . The pair $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is an equivalence relation in $\mathcal{A}$*

Proof. First we show that $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is a regular epi is an internal relation. So we need to show that $\langle \text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi \rangle$ is a mono. Consider the following diagram of solid arrows¹. It commutes, in fact

- $(p\gamma)\text{proj}_{2,C} = 1_B(p\gamma)\text{proj}_{2,C} = p\text{proj}_{1,C} = p\gamma\xi$
- $1_B(p\gamma)p_2 = 1_B(p\gamma)p_1 = p\gamma p_1$

Thus we can consider the morphism h' induced by the universal property of the

¹[ST92] assumes the existence of coequalizers, which is not the case in our setting. However, this is not a problem: at this point, we can use the morphism $p\gamma$ instead of the coequalizer of $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$, as it serves our purpose. Then, *a posteriori*, this proposition ensures, under the assumption of exact category, that the pair $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ has a coequalizer, which we will make use of.

pullback from p_2 and γp_1 , and h similarly induced from $\text{proj}_{2,C}$ and ξ .

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
 E \times_B C & & & & \\
 \swarrow \text{proj}_{1,C} & \searrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & & & \\
 & C \times_B C & \xrightarrow{p_2} & C & \\
 & \downarrow p_1 & & \downarrow p\gamma & \\
 & C & \xrightarrow{p\gamma} & B & \\
 & \downarrow \gamma & & \downarrow 1_B & \\
 & E & \xrightarrow{p} & B &
 \end{array}$$

ξ (curved arrow from $E \times_B C$ to C)
 h (dashed arrow from $E \times_B C$ to $C \times_B C$)
 h' (dashed arrow from $C \times_B C$ to $E \times_B C$)

In order to prove that $\langle \text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi \rangle$ is a mono, we need to show that h is a mono. Since $(\text{proj}_{1,C}, \text{proj}_{2,C})$ is a jointly monic pair, by the following compositions

- $\text{proj}_{1,C} h' h = \gamma p_1 h = \gamma \xi = \text{proj}_{1,C} = \text{proj}_{1,C} 1_{E \times_B C}$
- $\text{proj}_{2,C} h' h = p_2 h = \text{proj}_{2,C} = \text{proj}_{2,C} 1_{E \times_B C}$

we have that $h'h = 1_{E \times_B C}$. This implies that h is a mono, in fact suppose that f and g are two morphisms such that $hf = hg$, then we have

$$\begin{aligned}
 hf &= hg \\
 \implies h'hf &= h'hg \\
 \implies 1_{E \times_B C} f &= 1_{E \times_B C} g \\
 \implies f &= g
 \end{aligned}$$

Consider now the canonical morphism $i : C \times_B C \rightarrow C \times C$ induced by the universal property of the product. We have that i is a mono, in fact f and g are two

morphisms such that $if = ig$, then we have

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
 & & & C & \\
 & & p_1 \nearrow & \downarrow p'_1 & \\
 A & \xrightarrow[f]{g} & C \times_B C & \xrightarrow{i} & C \times C \\
 & & p_1 \searrow & \uparrow p'_2 & \\
 & & & C &
 \end{array}$$

- $if = ig \implies p'_1 if = p'_1 ig \implies p_1 f = p_1 g$
- $if = ig \implies p'_2 if = p'_2 ig \implies p_2 f = p_2 g$

Since (p_1, p_2) is a jointly monic pair, we have that $f = g$. Thus, i is a mono. Since i and h are both monos, we have that ih is a mono.

By the following commutative diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
 & & \text{proj}_{1,C} \nearrow & & C \\
 & & & \uparrow p'_1 & \\
 E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{h} & C \times_B C & \xrightarrow{i} & C \times C \\
 & & p_2 \searrow & \downarrow p'_2 & \\
 & & & & C \\
 & & \text{proj}_{2,C} \searrow & &
 \end{array}$$

we conclude that $ih = \langle \text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi \rangle$, so $\langle \text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi \rangle$ is a mono.

We proved that $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is an internal relation, now we need to show that it is an equivalence, ie it is reflexive, symmetric and transitive.

- Claim: $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is reflexive.

Called η the unit of the monad, we have that $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)\eta_{(C,\gamma)} = \langle 1_C, 1_C \rangle$. In fact $\xi\eta_{(C,\gamma)} = 1_C$ and by the definition of the unit of the monad, we have that

$$\text{proj}_{2,C} \eta_{(C,\gamma)} = \text{proj}_{2,C} \langle \gamma, 1_C \rangle = 1_C.$$

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} & & C & & \\ & \swarrow 1_C & \downarrow \eta_{(C,\gamma)} & \searrow 1_C & \\ C & \xleftarrow{\text{proj}_{2,C}} & E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\xi} & C \end{array}$$

- Claim: $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is symmetric.

Consider the following diagram, where $\text{proj}_{1,E \times_B C}$ and $\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C}$ are the projections of $E \times_B (E \times_B C)$. Let l be the morphism induced by the universal property of the pullback from $1_{E \times_B C}$ and $\gamma \text{proj}_{2,C}$, in particular it is the unique such that

$$\gamma \text{proj}_{2,C} = l \text{proj}_{1,E \times_B C} = l \text{proj}_{1,C} (1_E \times \text{proj}_{2,C})$$

and

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} & & 1_{E \times_B C} = l \text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C} & & \\ & & \text{---} 1_{E \times_B C} \text{---} & & \\ & & \text{---} & & \\ E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\quad l \quad} & E \times_B (E \times_B C) & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C}} & E \times_B C \\ \downarrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & & \downarrow 1_E \times_B \text{proj}_{2,C} & & \downarrow 1_E \times_B \xi \\ & & E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,C}} & C \\ & & \downarrow \text{proj}_{1,C} & & \downarrow p\gamma \\ & & E & \xrightarrow{p} & B \end{array}$$

Define $\sigma = (1_E \times_B \xi)l$. Observe that

$$\text{proj}_{2,C} \sigma = \text{proj}_{2,C} (1_E \times_B \xi) l = \xi 1_{E \times_B C} = \xi$$

It remains to show that $\xi \sigma = \text{proj}_{2,C}$. This holds because of the following compositions and the fact that $(\text{proj}_{1,C}, \text{proj}_{2,C})$ is a jointly monic pair.

- $\text{proj}_{1,C}(1_E \times_B \text{proj}_{2,C})l = \text{proj}_{1,E \times_B C}l = \gamma \text{proj}_{2,C}$
- $\text{proj}_{1,C}\eta_{(C,\gamma)}\text{proj}_{2,C} = \text{proj}_{1,C}\langle \gamma, 1_C \rangle \text{proj}_{2,C} = \gamma \text{proj}_{2,C}$
- $\text{proj}_{2,C}(1_E \times_B \text{proj}_{2,C})l = \text{proj}_{2,C}\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C}l = \text{proj}_{2,C}1_{E \times_B C} = \text{proj}_{2,C}$
- $\text{proj}_{2,C}\eta_{(C,\gamma)}\text{proj}_{2,C} = \text{proj}_{1,C}\langle \gamma, 1_C \rangle \text{proj}_{2,C} = 1_C \text{proj}_{2,C} = \text{proj}_{2,C}$

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
& & E \times_B C & & \\
& \swarrow \xi & \downarrow \sigma = (1 \times_B \xi)l & \searrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & \\
C & & & & C \\
& \nwarrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & & \nearrow \xi & \\
& & E \times_B C & &
\end{array}$$

- Claim: $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ is transitive.
Consider the pullback (???)

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
(E \times_B C) \times_C (E \times_B C) & \longrightarrow & E \times_B C \\
\downarrow & & \downarrow \xi \\
E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,C}} & C
\end{array}$$

□

In an exact category each equivalence relation is a kernel pair and by (CITE) has a coequalizer. Thus in an exact category $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ has a coequalizer. Let $q : C \rightarrow Q$ be such coequalizer. Observe that considering $\text{proj}_{2,C}$ and ξ as morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, then q is a morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$ as well by the universal property. So, called δ the morphism induced by the universal property of the coequalizer from $\text{proj}_{2,C}$ and ξ , we have that q with codomain (Q, δ) is also the coequalizer of the pair in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$.

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{\xi} & C & \xrightarrow{q} & Q \\
& \searrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & \downarrow p\gamma & \swarrow \delta & \\
& & B & &
\end{array}$$

Consider the comparison functor $K : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$ defined as $K(D, \zeta) = (p^*(D, \zeta), p^*(\epsilon_{(D,\zeta)}))$, where ϵ is the counit of the adjunction, and $\epsilon_{(D,\zeta)}$ is defined as the projection from $E \times_B D$ to D of the pullback of p along ζ .

In our context of exact category, turns out that the comparison functor K has a left adjoint $L : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$ defined as $L(C, \gamma; \xi) = (Q, \delta)$, where (Q, δ) is the codomain of coequalizer of the pair $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$.

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
 (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) & \xrightleftharpoons[L]{K} & (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T \\
 \uparrow p! & \nearrow F^T & \\
 \downarrow p^* & \nwarrow U^T & \\
 (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E) & &
 \end{array}$$

Let us introduce the counit ρ and counit α of the adjunction $K \dashv L$. For each object (D, ζ) in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$ the counit is a morphism of the kind $\rho_{(D, \zeta)} : LK(D, \zeta) \rightarrow (D, \zeta)$. First we compute $K(D, \zeta)$.

$$K(D, \zeta) = (E \times_B D, \text{proj}_{1,D}; p^*(\text{proj}_{2,D}))$$

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
 E \times_B D & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,D}} & D \\
 \downarrow \text{proj}_{1,D} & & \downarrow \zeta \\
 E & \xrightarrow{p} & B
 \end{array}$$

Then, call $q' : E \times_B D \rightarrow Q'$ the coequalizer of the equivalence relation $(\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B D}, p^*(\text{proj}_{2,D}))$, as done above we make it a coequalizer in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$ via the universal property. We obtain $q' : (E \times_B D, p\text{proj}_{1,D}) \rightarrow (Q', \delta')$. Then compute $LK(D, \zeta)$. By (CITE) the top left square in the diagram below is a pullback, in particular we have that it commutes. Thus we can define as in the diagram below the morphism $\rho_{(D, \zeta)}$ by the universal property of the coequalizer q' .

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
 E \times_B (E \times_B D) & \xrightleftharpoons[\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B D}]{p^*(\text{proj}_{2,D})} & E \times_B D & \xrightarrow{q'} & Q' \\
 \downarrow \text{proj}_{2,E \times_B D} & & \downarrow \text{proj}_{2,D} & \nearrow \rho_{(D, \zeta)} & \\
 E \times_B D & \xrightarrow{\text{proj}_{2,D}} & D & & \\
 \downarrow \text{proj}_{1,D} & \nearrow \text{proj}_{1,D} & \downarrow \zeta & & \\
 E & \xrightarrow{p} & B & \xleftarrow{\delta'} & Q'
 \end{array} \tag{1}$$

Observe that δ' was also defined as the morphism induced by the universal property of the coequalizer, considering the object $E \times_B D$ as an object in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$ via $p\text{proj}_{1,D}$, thus $\rho_{(D,\zeta)}$ is a morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, ie $\zeta\rho_{(D,\zeta)} = \delta$.

For each object $(C, \gamma; \xi)$ in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$ the unit is a morphism of the kind $\alpha_{(C,\gamma;\xi)} : (C, \gamma; \xi) \rightarrow KL(C, \gamma; \xi)$. We compute $KL(C, \gamma; \xi)$. Let $q : C \rightarrow Q$ be the coequalizer of the equivalence relation $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ in $\mathcal{A}$. By the universal property of the coequalizer, we have that q is a morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, via the projection $p\gamma$ from C to B . Thus, we can consider the coequalizer of the equivalence relation $(\text{proj}_{2,C}, \xi)$ in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, which we denote by $q : (C, p\gamma) \rightarrow (Q, \delta)$. By functoriality, we have that $p^*(q)p^*(\xi) = p^*(q)p^*(\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C})$. Moreover, it holds that ξ is the coequalizer of $(p^*(\xi), p^*(\text{proj}_{2,C}))$ (WHY?). Thus we can define $\alpha_{(C,\gamma;\xi)}$ as the morphism induced by the universal property of the coequalizer q as done in the diagram below. One can check that $\alpha_{(C,\gamma;\xi)}$ is a morphism in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$.

$$\begin{array}{ccccc}
 E \times_B (E \times_B C) & \xrightarrow[p^*(\text{proj}_{2,E \times_B C})]{p^*(\xi)} & E \times_B C & \xrightarrow{p^*(q)} & E \times_B Q \\
 \downarrow \text{proj}_{1,E \times_B C} & & \downarrow \text{proj}_{2,C} & \nearrow \alpha_{(C,\gamma;\xi)} & \downarrow \text{proj}_{2,Q} \\
 E \times_B C & \xrightarrow[\text{proj}_{2,C}]{\xi} & C & \xrightarrow{q} & Q \\
 \downarrow \text{proj}_{1,C} & \nearrow \gamma & \downarrow p\gamma & \nearrow \delta & \\
 E & \xrightarrow{p} & B & &
 \end{array} \tag{2}$$

One can show that ρ and α are natural transformations, and that they satisfy the universal property of the counit / unit. This follows from the universal property of the coequalizer of the equivalence relation considered.

Our goal is to show that p^* is a monadic functor, ie that the comparison functor K is an equivalence of categories. We prove that it is an adjoint equivalence, which is the same. In order to do so, we aim to prove that the unit α and the counit ρ of the adjunction $L \dashv K$ are pointwise isomorphisms.

Proposition 2. *In an exact category if $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a regular epi, then the counit ρ of the adjunction $L \dashv K$ is a pointwise isomorphism.*

Proof. We aim to prove that for each object (D, ζ) in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, the morphism $\rho_{(D,\zeta)} : LK(D, \zeta) \rightarrow (D, \zeta)$ is an isomorphism. Consider the diagram (1) of the definition

of the counit $\rho_{(D,\zeta)}$. An exact category is also regular, in particular regular epi are pullback stable. If p is a regular epi, then $\text{proj}_{2,D}$ is a regular epi as well. The top left square is a pullback by (CITE), thus $(p^*(\text{proj}_{2,D}), \text{proj}_{2,E \times_B D})$ is the kernel pair of $\text{proj}_{2,D}$. Since $\text{proj}_{2,D}$ is a regular epi, then, by (CITE), it is the coequalizer of its kernel pair $(p^*(\text{proj}_{2,D}), \text{proj}_{2,E \times_B D})$. We have that q and $\text{proj}_{2,D}$ are coequalizers of the same pair, thus the morphism $\rho_{(D,\zeta)}$ defined by the universal property of the coequalizer q is actually an isomorphism. $\square$

Proposition 3. *In an exact category the unit α of the adjunction $L \dashv K$ is a pointwise isomorphism.*

Proof. We aim to prove that for each object (C, γ, ξ) in $(\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, the morphism $\rho_{(D,\zeta)} : LK(D, \zeta) \rightarrow (D, \zeta)$ is an isomorphism. Consider the diagram (2). An exact category is also regular, in particular regular epi are pullback stable. Since q is a regular epi, then $p^*(q)$ is a regular epi as well. Moreover, since q is the coequalizer of $(\xi, \text{proj}_{2,C})$ which is a kernel pair, then by (CITE) $(\xi, \text{proj}_{2,C})$ is the kernel pair of q . Then, since p^* is a right adjoint, it preserves kernel pairs, thus $(p^*(\xi), p^*(\text{proj}_{2,C}))$ is the kernel pair of $p^*(q)$. We already proved that $p^*(q)$ is a regular epi, then by (CITE) it is the coequalizer of its kernel pair $(p^*(\xi), p^*(\text{proj}_{2,C}))$. We have that $p^*(q)$ and ξ are coequalizers of the same pair, thus the morphism $\alpha_{(C,\gamma;\xi)}$ defined by the universal property of the coequalizer ξ is actually an isomorphism. $\square$

Finally, we have the main result we were aiming to prove.

Theorem 1. *In an exact category, if $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a regular epi, then p^* is a monadic functor.*

Proof. The exactness of the category implies that the comparison functor $K : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T$ has a left adjoint $L : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)^T \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B)$, as shown. By 3 and 2, the unit α and the counit ρ of the adjunction $L \dashv K$ are pointwise isomorphisms. Thus, $L \dashv K$ is an adjoint equivalence. This implies that K is an equivalence of categories. So $p^* : (\mathcal{A} \downarrow B) \rightarrow (\mathcal{A} \downarrow E)$ is a monadic functor. $\square$

References

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